

LIGHTS, SHADOWS, ACTION!

Planrs Academy — Shadow Puppet Theatre | Grade 1 | 30 Minutes

"Every shadow tells a story — what's YOURS?"

Discover the magic of light and shadow through puppet-making, storytelling, and performance — rooted in India's rich tradition of shadow puppet arts from Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, and Karnataka.

■ Subject	Creative Arts — Shadow Puppet Theatre	■ Duration	30 Minutes
■ Grade	Grade 1 (Age 6–7)	■ Level	Beginner
■ Prepared by	Curriculum Design Team, Planrs Academy	■ Version	1.0 April 2026

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SECTION 1

Learning Objectives

LO 1	Understand	Explain what a shadow is and connect to an Indian tradition (e.g. Tholpavakoothu, Kerala)
LO 2	Observe	Show how distance from light changes shadow size — closer = bigger, farther = smaller
LO 3	Create	Design and cut at least one shadow puppet character from card paper on a stick handle
LO 4	Perform	Use the puppet to perform a short 2–3 sentence story, speaking at least one line aloud
LO 5	Connect	Name at least one Indian state with a shadow puppet tradition and describe what makes it special
LO 6 ■	Reflect (Stretch)	Observe how light, distance, and angle change their puppet's shadow using own words

SECTION 2 — PHASE 1 (0:00 – 3:00)

Hook: The Mystery Shadow Game

■ Story Setup	Turn off lights. Shine torch on wall. Make a hand shadow (bird/dog shape). Ask: <i>'What do you see? Is it real or a shadow? How did it get there?'</i> Reveal: it was just a hand! Build excitement: 'THAT is the magic of shadow puppets!'
■ Whole-Class Questions	• Put your hand up if you have ever seen your own shadow! • Can you make your shadow do THIS? [wave, spin] Students copy! • What do you think makes a shadow? Show me with your hands!
■ Bridge Statement	"To make a shadow, we need LIGHT and something to BLOCK the light. Today we will make a whole puppet theatre — and learn about Indian artists who have been doing this for THOUSANDS of years!"
■ Props Needed	Torch / phone flashlight • White wall or white dupatta over doorway • Optional: pre-made simple puppet for demonstration

India's Shadow Puppet Traditions

Shadow puppet theatre is one of India's oldest art forms — over 2,000 years old! Introduce two traditions maximum (Kerala + one regional). One fact per tradition at Grade 1 level.

Tholpavakoothu

Kerala

- Made from:** Deer or goat leather (card paper in classrooms)
- Stories:** Episodes from the Ramayana
- Special fact:** Performed at temple festivals; puppets can be over 1 metre tall! Screen = Kaithari

Tholu Bommalata

Andhra Pradesh & Telangana

- Made from:** Translucent goat leather, brightly painted
- Stories:** Mahabharata and Ramayana stories
- Special fact:** COLOURED shadows! Light shines through painted leather — screen glows

Ravanachhaya

Odisha

- Made from:** Single whole piece of deer hide — no joints!
- Stories:** Story of Ravana from the Ramayana
- Special fact:** Enormous puppets — the whole puppet moves as ONE piece; no bending joints!

Togalu Gombeyaata

Karnataka

- Made from:** Leather; puppet size varies by character type
- Stories:** Puranic stories and folk tales
- Special fact:** Big puppets = important characters; small puppets = everyday people — size =

■ ■ Point to the
MAP

Kerala → Andhra Pradesh → Odisha → Karnataka — show each state while introducing the tradition. This grounds the child in geography alongside art history.

SECTION 4

What Is a Shadow? + The 3-Part Theatre Setup

■ ■ Definition

A shadow forms when an object **BLOCKS light** from passing through. The blocked area behind the object appears dark — that dark shape is the shadow.

■ Indian Analogy

"On a hot summer afternoon, when you stand under a neem tree, the tree blocks the sunlight and its shadow falls on you — keeping you cool! That cool dark patch IS a shadow!"

■ Key Point

The shape of the shadow **matches the shape** of the object blocking the light — almost like a dark copy! The puppet must be **OPAQUE** (solid, not see-through).

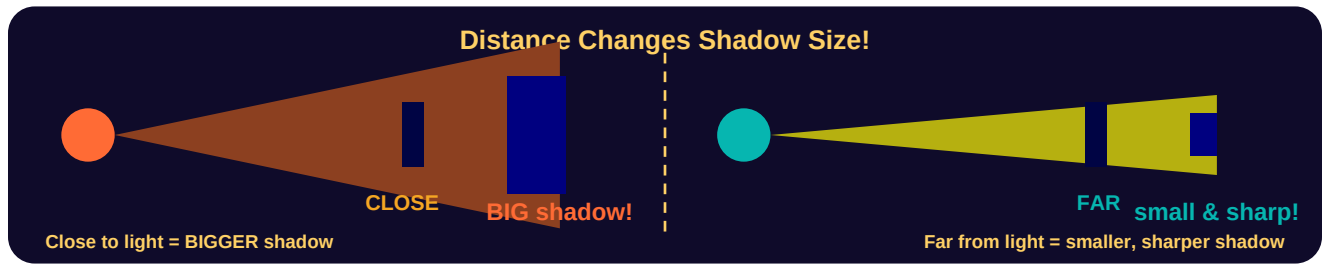
Theatre Setup — Always in This Order:



The PUPPET goes between the light and the screen. The audience sits in FRONT of the screen — they see only the shadow, never the puppet artist! Just like the Tholpavakoothu performers of Kerala.

SECTION 5 — PHASE 4 (20:00 – 24:00)

Shadow Size Experiments



Experiment	What to Do	Expected Discovery
■ Size Magic	Move puppet closer to torch → watch shadow grow. Move farther → shadow shrinks.	Close to light = BIG shadow. Far from light = small, sharp shadow.
■ Angle Play	Tilt puppet left, right, upside down. Ask: does your character look like it's flying? Bowing?	Different angles = different poses. Tilting creates movement and expression!
■ Partner Puppets	Two students, two puppets on screen at the same time. Can they meet, wave, talk?	Two shadows can interact — this previews the performance and builds excitement!

SECTION 6 — PHASE 3 (10:00 – 20:00)

Puppet Making — Step by Step

■ Materials Per Student

• 1 sheet black card paper (A5 size)	• Safety scissors
• 1 pencil (silver/white pencil for black card)	• 1 wooden ice-cream stick or straw (handle)
• Cello tape or glue	• Optional: hole punch for pattern cut-outs

Step	Action	Facilitator Tip	Time
A Choose	Pick ONE character — animal, person, or object. Make it big and bold — simple shapes make the BEST shadows!	Show examples: peacock, elephant, farmer, mango tree. Silhouettes work best.	1 min
B Draw	Draw the character as a SILHOUETTE (solid filled shape) on black card. No internal details needed — only the outline!	"Don't worry about perfect — a shadow is just a SHAPE! Bold lines, big shape!"	3 min
C Cut	Cut along the outline with safety scissors. Cut OUTSIDE the line, not on it, for best results.	Circulate and assist with curves. Fast finishers: use hole punch to add patterns like traditional leather puppets!	4 min

D Attach	Tape or glue the ice-cream stick/straw to the BACK of the puppet as a handle, near the middle or bottom.	"Stick goes on the BACK — so the audience can't see it, only the shadow!"	2 min
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SECTION 7

Story Structure for Your Shadow Show

START

Who is in your story?
Where are they?

MIDDLE

What happens?
What problem do they face?

END

How does it finish?
Happy ending!

Indian Story Starter Ideas ■

■	A little elephant who lost her way in the jungle and found a friendly rabbit to guide her home
■ ■	A farmer (Kisan) who planted seeds in the monsoon rain and watched them grow tall
■	Two birds who argued over a mango tree branch and learned to share
■	A child who found a magic diya that granted one kind wish
■	A peacock (Mor) who danced in the rain and made everyone happy

Approved Indian Puppet Characters

Peacock (Mor), Elephant (Haathi), Crow (Kauwa), Snake (Saap), Cow (Gaay), Fish (Machli), Tiger (Sher), Monkey (Bandar), Parrot (Tota)	Farmer (Kisan) with plough, Grandmother (Dadi/Nani), Child with school bag, Vendor (Sabziwala), Bharatanatyam dancer, Cricket player	Banyan/ neem/ mango tree, Mountain, River boat, Diya/ lamp, Moon and stars, Rain cloud, Village hut (triangular roof)
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SECTION 8 — PHASE 5 (24:00 – 28:00)

Performance Rules + Mini Shadow Show

■ Rule	What it means
1 — Be kind	Every puppet show is wonderful — even a 2-second performance!
2 — Always clap	Audience claps after EVERY performance, no exceptions.
3 — Partners welcome	Nervous students may perform with a friend or partner.
4 — Mistakes = magic	The show must go on — mistakes are part of the theatre magic!



The Cultural Chant — Say Together!



LIGHT it! ■

[mime torch shining]

BLOCK it! ■

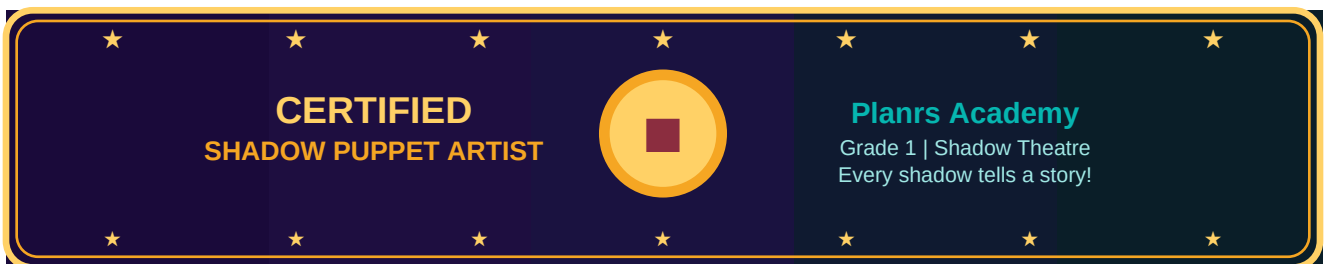
[hold hand in front]

SHOW it! ■

[mime puppet on screen]

That's SHADOW ART! Woo-hoo! ■

■ ■ Puppet Parade	Ask all students to hold up their puppet for a "puppet parade" — celebrate the variety! "Look at all these amazing puppets! Every one is different — just like puppet artists across India!"
■ Gallery Question	Show 2 completed puppets (or shadow photos). Ask: "Which puppet do you think makes the BIGGER shadow? Why?" Build critical thinking.
■ Badge Award	"You created a shadow puppet and performed — you are a SHADOW PUPPET ARTIST, just like the artists of Kerala and Andhra Pradesh! You are CERTIFIED!" (Show badge graphic on screen)



■ Parent Corner	For fast f • Make a magical o • Create a SEARCH • Sentence lesson is: Creative REAL LIFE screen. A Bring you ■ Stretch Challenge
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Quick Reference: Key Vocabulary

Shadow	The dark shape behind a puppet when light is blocked
Light source	Something that gives out light (torch, sun, diya, lamp)
Block	Stop the light from passing through

Screen	The white cloth or paper that the shadow appears on
Puppet	Our cut-out character that blocks the light
Performance	When we show our shadow play to an audience
Tholpavakoothu	Kerala's traditional leather shadow puppet art — 2,000+ years old!
Tholu Bommalata	Andhra Pradesh's coloured shadow puppet tradition — glowing coloured shadows!

Every shadow tells a story — what's YOURS? ■■

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